

THE GOOD WEEKEND



We don't have a video — they soften the brain

By KEITH DUNSTAN

WE ARE starting to feel humiliated. We don't possess a video cassette recorder.

Yet if you are clever you can always pick up social points by being the absolute last. We had a leader writer once who would announce firmly at dinner parties: "We don't have a TV set."

When the shock had subsided, he would announce in superior tones that he and his wife believed that television softened the brain and they still read books.

Actually, it wasn't an original idea. Back in the 40s we had another leader writer. Terribly elegant, he was. He even sported a monocle.

At dinner parties, when everybody was talking about Jack Davey, Bob Dyer, the Lux Radio Theatre and Blue Hills, he would say: "We have never descended to purchasing a radio. We still believe in the value of the written word."

By heavens, they are closing in. The figures are: 25 per cent of the population have VCRs; it will be 40 per cent by Christmas; and if you don't have one by 1990, probably they will fine you or put you in jail.

Already some PR firms take it for granted everybody has a video. Rather than put pen to paper they send in videotapes, presuming you will take them home and observe their wonderful spiel on your TV set. I send them back with the message: "Terribly sorry, we don't have a VCR. Videos soften the brain."

Even worse, schools now have VCRs, and kids are expected to take home tapes as part of their education program.

WE WERE at a dinner party the other night and I announced: "That was a great episode of Carson's Law last night."

Charlie Fink, in superior style, replied: "We haven't seen it yet. Last night we were at the opera. But we will take it in tomorrow night if we get the time. We have it in the can, you know."

That's if he's lucky. Charlie has one of those wonderful sets which operate on a clock device. He can go away on holidays and set the thing so that it will pick up Carson's Law, M*A*S*H, Magnum and have a great brain-softening session when he comes home.

But it's so complicated. One time he thought he had the finals of the Open tennis, and when he came to view it was the Reverend Schuller with his morning service from Los Angeles.

Another time he invited us round to see Casablanca. But when he turned it on, oh dear, he had lost the first hour entirely. All the great stuff when Humphrey Bogart says, "Play it, Sam" and "Of all the cheap joints in all the world..."

We had to put up with an hour of river rafting in Canada. Charlie, when he set the switch, forgot to allow for daylight saving. Then sometimes we go to Larry and Sandra's place. Larry was always first with the electronics. He had a TV set early in 1956 before broadcasts started and he would sit for hours looking at the test pattern. He was the first in our street to get stereo and he told us how hideous life was with one speaker. He led the field with CB radio and it was quite some time before he stopped conversing in truckie talk. Now he has a living room with a complete electronics display. It looks like the control room at the SEC.

WELL, Larry has a fetish that A Clockwork Orange is the best movie ever made. Three times now we have been to his house. As soon as dinner was over, the lights went out — no conversation — and on went A Clockwork Orange while Larry and Sandra went to sleep.

But things can be worse. Our friends, Phil and Ruby, gave each other one of these video cameras for Christmas. They say it all cost them about \$1,500.

Ah, but once having bought the thing, apart from spending six months' housekeeping on batteries, it costs almost nothing to run. So they have about 40 hours on tape now, recording every movement, every whimper of their kids.

What's more they have a special trick. When you arrive there's Phil with his camera, battery gear and all, loaded down like Hilary climbing Mt Everest, and he does a complete recording of the pre-dinner drinks.

After dinner — surprise. He puts on the tape. It's all there on the screen. There are Mabel's lucid comments on the weather, Jack's extraordinary insights on the quality of administration of the Collingwood Football Club and Russell's story about the three nuns.

When that's all over we get part of the 40 hours of shots of the kids and the holiday at Merimbula.

So what is the next device which will be death not to have? I suspect it will be the video disc. The tiny laser-operated metal disc you will just slip into your machine, and it will give sound plus visual; store 100 hours in a tenth of the space.

Perhaps we'd better pop out and be the first on the block to get one.

Against all odds, Emmie is about to start school with the others

ANN WARNER charts the progress of her afflicted child and her own search for spiritual answers

EMMIE starts school next week.

Like every other six-year-old in the neighbourhood she will depart shinily-shod, pressed crisp, her scarlet schoolbag tossed about at the bus stop as she ripples with the excitement of it all.

Unlike many others, Emmie will explode into the life of school. She will squeak shrilly, racing her big brother, unafraid.

As I look back six years, I'm not sure how we both survived.

To begin with, Emmie should have been an abortion. The doctor who predicted congenital anomalies was right. Under the crop of thick auburn hair, Emmie has two hearing aids and a scrambled brain. Medications mask the epilepsy which haunts her, and strong drugs hold down her hyperactivity and other neurological problems.

Years of intensive early intervention have prepared Emmie for the moment of absolute normalcy... starting at the local school at age six. It will be her fourth school, and the teachers perhaps share my trepidation because she comes from special ed — the dark side of schools.

The doctor who forecast a child with spots and wrinkles was wrong in several ways. Emmie's intelligence is unimpaired; she has already learned to read and write a little. And the problem wasn't caused by the drugs which crossed my placenta during pregnancy. I could have terminated that pregnancy on a wrong premise. A boy child conceived in perfect conditions, born two years after Emmie, has the same odd heap of little disabilities.

The doctor who warned me about the potential of my blubbery 16-week-old foetus probably used language which set my squeamishness against further tests. I can vaguely remember describing amniocentesis to my husband one miserable wet weekend in a hotel on the south coast. It seemed a heroic decision not only to go ahead with the pregnancy, but also to accept whatever a nameless fate dished out.

There was no hint of religious commitment against an abortion. The only sacred thought I had ever entertained about abortion was during my childhood years, as we contemplated a nine-year wait for adoption: "Wouldn't it be a far better thing," I would muse, "if some of these girls went ahead with their unwanted pregnancies so people like me might adopt?"

In the mid-70s one unmarried woman aged 40 went through with a pregnancy to produce a boy whom we would ultimately adopt. The woman lived in Jakarta, and we went there for a long holiday while the Indonesians tried to comply with Australian adoption requirements. There, on the steamy, stinking streets, people who somehow knew our purpose offered us cheap, brain-damaged babies... perfectly formed little creatures of immense beauty yet dull eyed and lifeless. At an orphanage we saw fragile children, black eyes urgent with invitation. Yet their bodies were full of syphilis, rickets and worms. They were the children of drug addicts and prostitutes, dumped with the city's garbage. By Australian standards such children were not adoptable. The search for a perfect child, a child who could be kept healthy, proved hard.

By the time we had a visa for the baby of our choice, he was a well grown toddler. "Look," our Chinese friends urged, "his ears stick

out and he has spots from this skin disease. Let's keep looking." We would not change our minds.

THEY say the Blue Mountains air is like champagne. The faint, acrid tinge of burnt bush invaded my nostrils when we returned home... and every time I went outside I threw up. Though far from the mass of brown flesh which is Jakarta I could still smell the marketplace, and I could still taste the violent, sense-shattering mixtures of roast goat flesh and rotten vegetables. I kept throwing up.

The Chinese had warned me. Australian friends grinned knowingly. And then that wretched doctor confirmed it: I was pregnant.

The chronicle of what had crossed my placenta in the first four months of this unexpected pregnancy revealed a certain wantonness in me. First, I had been much vaccinated. Then I had swallowed pills — for Bali belly, to prevent malaria, for travel sickness, for a gall bladder attack, something for my nerves, and yes, I had run out of Thyroxine and completely abandoned my normal medications.

On top of all this, with the urgency of conception forgotten, I had indulged piggyishly in cigarettes and alcohol. The doctor was appalled.

The foetus, which was Emmie, was not only small, but she emerged frail, screaming and badly nourished a month earlier than expected. At 16 weeks of age she was a stringy, purplish scrap, not much over three kilos. She had infections, allergies, colic, indigestion; she vomited incessantly and she rarely slept.

The first three years of Emmie's life were probably the most harrowing of my own allotted span. This wild bird, her mouth forever open, her neck stretching to gaze at the world, failed to learn the most basic facts of life: "Hot!", "Stop!", "No, no, no!"

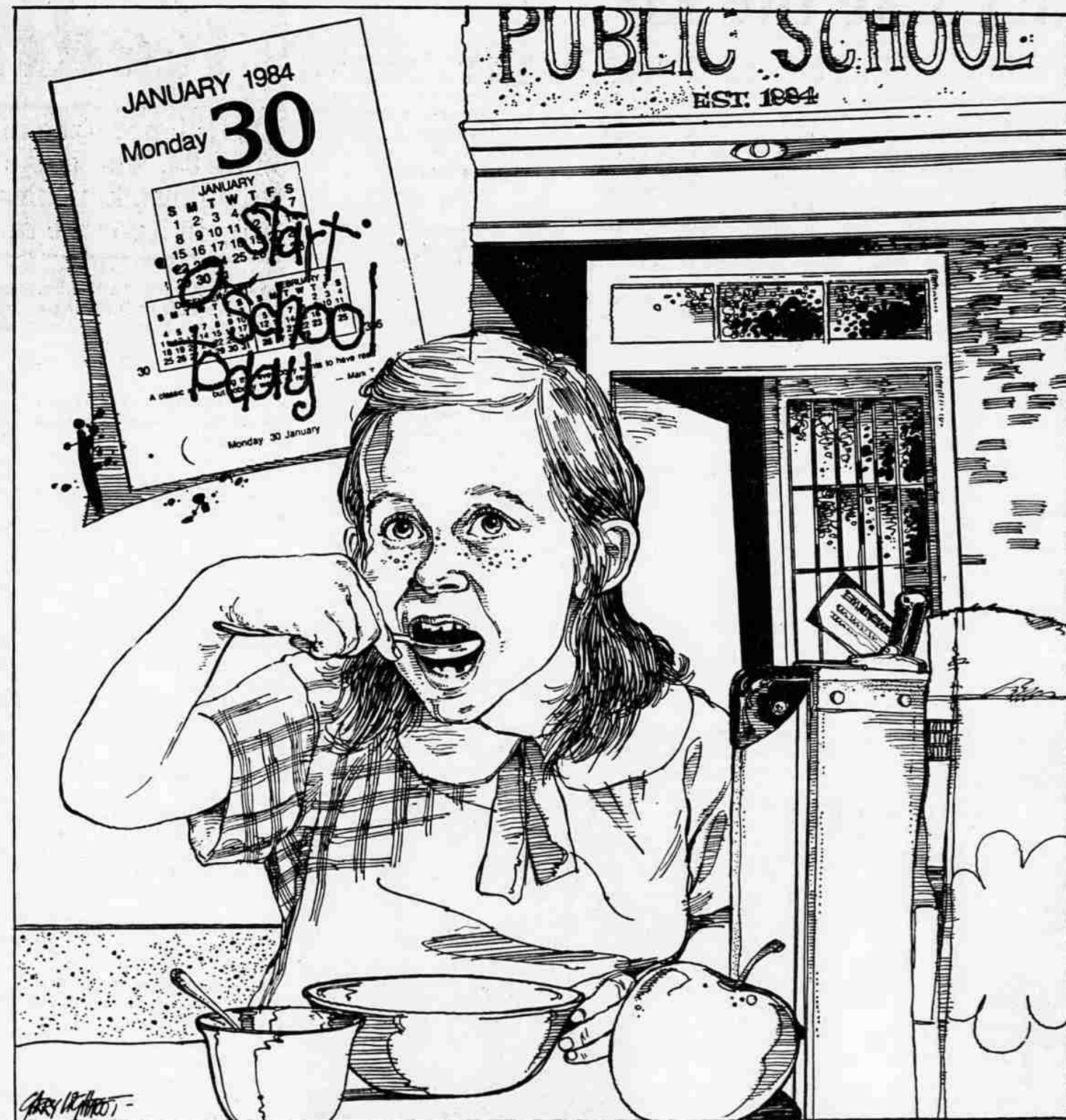
She was impossibly hyperactive and did not know her own name. The first neurologist to report on Emmie recorded her attention-span as three seconds. The evening she was hospitalised at the Royal Alexandra Hospital for Children she tried to scale the third-storey balcony. Medication slowed her down.

Another factor came into op-

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eration just here. It was prayer. Jakarta, brain-damaged babies and my own Emmie had melted cynicism and a peculiar faith grew out of one Christian woman's concern: she came to me with her dreams and advice, and in fear of fanaticism I fled to the Anglican rector. He could not deny the possibility that God authored dreams. Cautiously, I investigated.

My own health was breaking down with the stress of caring for a wild, sleepless child, and the only hope of help was offered by a small school for the intellectually disabled. Friends protested, but Emmie settled quickly as a day



child, ferried by bus from my front door. The strong routine worked to her advantage, and like old-fashioned cream in milk she rose to the top of the bottle. She became toilet-trained, she kept her clothes on, she learned to eat her sandwich while seated, and she became more confident and controlled. She straddled the voluptuous hips of her teacher and, with calm, hungry eyes, she took in that woman's great booming voice.

Emmie began to articulate with the same regimented clarity of this

ONE muggy Parramatta Monday, in the ominous hush of the Acoustic Laboratories, a gentle audiologist explained that my son's hearing was impaired. He made it sound like a minor inconvenience, vaguely akin to deafness. Seventeen minutes later he insisted upon testing Emmie, and announced the same shattering results.

Months later, on a bitter July morning, a busy and businesslike ophthalmologist flicked through my family's history impassively. A gen-

In the long months of adjustment I stood my own ancestor, with her brood of a dozen, alongside Queen Victoria, and I tried to imagine the consequences of aborting the afflicted in either family.

My mind reeled in protest against my ugly ancestors and all that their wretched genes had wrought... yet I had this whimsical game in which I eradicated those afflicted with haemophilia, or the carriers, in the royal families of Europe.

What if there had been no Czarina, no powerful consort for the Kaiser, no sickly heirs to the Spanish and British thrones?

And then there was Beethoven, born out of a family of deaf, blind, syphilitic, tubercular siblings.

Such games were my salvation. Emmie's first grand mal seizure came around her fourth birthday. I found her like a tangled heap of dirty washing, unconscious on the bedroom floor. As I found her eyes rolled back and unravelled her limbs, the little body contorted and began to vibrate in a grotesque dance that spun her 360 degrees.

I was astonished only that she did not die. In accepting the imperfections of a child, there is acceptance of the unknown. When epilepsy came I searched out the great men who also carried this spot in their bodies through life.

I was searching, also, for spiritual answers. The ones which I accepted were found where I least expected... in the bosom of a Protestant church. It was a deeply spiritual decision in 1983 to take responsibility for an unadoptable, a child whose right to live, today, is much questioned.

THE child we adopted was physically deformed and deaf. What began as a Jack-in-the-Beanstalk climb to lofty idealism ended with an amazingly normal baby of Nordic beauty, a child with a cheerful temperament and wily determination.

In five years, like Emmie, he will set out down our long laneway of English shrubs and conifers to go to a normal school. He may dream of driving trains, buses or planes, and he might even consider becoming prime minister.

Science can turn this child into a perfect specimen. His hearing can be perfectly restored with microsurgery. His anatomical deficit can be repaired with plastic surgery.

When I see my houseful of children and consider their candidature for abortion: the two bearing my family's genetic affliction, the waif from the back streets of Jakarta, and the unadoptable infant, I wonder who died today. I think of Beethoven and all those English kings, and I consider the lists of great men and the spots and wrinkles they bore through life.

The disability fades as the man emerges, and every early difficulty seems a speck by comparison with the great victories life holds for the children who endure, and overcome.

There were many noble bastards, many motherless great men who arrived as change babies, many artists and poets.

As a Christian I cannot separate the foetus from its full-grown potential. As a mother who was saved from a great mistake, I sometimes thank God for Emmie.

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